Cheng Chen

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Education

Tongji University, Shanghai, China — Sept. 2023 – Present
B.Eng. in Electrical Engineering, College of Electronic and Information Engineering
Major Rank: **3/87**

Publications

- Yi Xu*, **Cheng Chen***, Wenzhuo Lei.
  If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization
  ACM MM 2026 (Accepted; Oral).
- **Cheng Chen***, Yi Xu*, Mufan Cao.
  OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment
  IJCAI 2026 (Accepted; Oral).
- **Cheng Chen**, et al.
  Neural-Operator Risk Assessment for Deployable Risk Triage
  NeurIPS 2026 (Under Review).

* equal contribution.

Research Experiences

If You Hear It, Help Find It: Orthogonal Knowledge Distillation for Open-Vocabulary Audio-Visual Event Localization

Accepted at **ACM MM 2026**, Co-first Author

- Addressed the difficulty of open-vocabulary audio-visual event localization, where heterogeneous audio and visual teachers provide uneven supervision and naive distillation propagates modality-specific errors.
- Proposed **OvOrthKD**, extending orthogonal feature distillation to audio-visual learning so complementary cross-modal cues are preserved while unreliable teacher signals are suppressed.
- Built a lightweight open-vocabulary localization pipeline accepted as an **oral** presentation at ACM Multimedia 2026.

OrthKD: Extracting Generalized Clinical Knowledge from Heterogeneous Teachers for Lightweight Deployment

Accepted at **IJCAI 2026**, Co-first Author

- Addressed expertise asymmetry in multi-teacher distillation for diabetic retinopathy screening, where a weaker ViT teacher (**0.83 QWK**) harms students under standard logit fusion with a stronger CNN teacher (**0.88 QWK**).
- Proposed **OrthKD**, distilling only complementary feature-level context from the weak teacher while enforcing orthogonality between teacher projections to avoid redundant knowledge transfer.
- Evaluated on **132,049** retinal images; the **5.4M**-parameter MobileNetV3 student reached **0.885 QWK** on EyePACS and improved zero-shot Messidor-2 performance from **0.507** to **0.728 QWK** (**+22.1** percentage points).

Neural-Operator Risk Assessment for Deployable Risk Triage

Submitted to **NeurIPS 2026**, First Author

- Addressed the deployment risk of neural operators in scientific computing, where incorrect operator predictions can silently corrupt downstream analysis without affordable post-hoc verification.
- Developed a single forward-pass risk assessment module that flags unreliable neural-operator outputs at inference time for deployable triage.
- Targeted low-overhead safety screening integrable into neural-operator pipelines without expensive ensemble or sampling-based uncertainty estimation.

Awards

- Provincial First Prize, China Robot and Artificial Intelligence Competition (2026), Team Captain
- National 2nd Prize, Global Campus AI Algorithm Elite Competition (2025), Team Captain
- National 3rd Prize, Embedded Chip & System Design Competition, FPGA track (2025), Team Captain

Skills

Programming: Python, PyTorch, Git, Linux, LaTeX, experiment tracking, LLM/agent prototyping.
Foundations: Machine Learning, Data Structures & Algorithms, Linear Algebra, Probability, Optimization, Information Theory, Signal Processing.
Passion: Deep enthusiasm for exploring the unknown and continuous learning across new areas.